4 The Indian Ocean Trade, 1500–1800

Indo-European trade laid the foundation for a new economic order in Asia and in Europe. Asian goods created new consumer markets in Europe. Asian trade had a formative effect on the world's money markets. In the eighteenth century, the European desire to maintain the supply of Asian goods contributed to the motivation to colonize. Indo-European trade was also the medium of transmission of new technological knowledge in both directions. There was so much two-way traffic that it would be hard to characterize the effects in terms of a model of European influence on India or an Indian "incorporation" into a European world economy. In any case, the hybrid technological, institutional, and political order that followed had momentous consequences for India. This chapter explores the evolution of Indo-European trade. The discussion leads to larger questions about the meaning of the trade for Indian history.

The Indian Ocean world at 1500

Situated in the middle of the "great arc" of Asian trade, India is geographically well placed to trade with both sides of the Indian Ocean.[1] It was not usual for any one merchant group to connect the extremities of the arc. Direct trade between West Asia and China was not unknown but, always rare, it declined after 1400. One consequence of that decline was the relative expansion of India's ports as points where cargo could change ships and ships could be restocked with food and water. This development strengthened the segments within the Indian Ocean and brought the West Asian and African ports of Aden, Hormuz, and Kilwa into closer contact with Malacca in Southeast Asia; at the same time, the middleman position of India grew. The Indian ports were more than transit points, however.

[1] I borrow the phrase from Om Prakash, *European Commercial Enterprise in Pre-colonial India*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1998.

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They were also markets themselves. The extent of India's land and the diversity of its resources made the ports sources for a variety of textiles, including silk and muslin, and for raw products like rice, sugar, oil, cotton, and indigo. India imported for its own consumption gold and silver, specialized consumer goods, horses, and, for the reexport business, a variety of spices. The spices came from the Indonesian islands to Cambay, to be forwarded to West Asia, and then onward to Europe.

Goods bound for Europe left the Indian shores (from Cambay or Calicut) to reach either Aden at the mouth of the Red Sea or Hormuz Island at the entry to the Persian Gulf. Arab merchants would convey the goods to either Suez or Tor at the northern end of the Red Sea, or Persian merchants would take them to Basra at the northwestern end of the Gulf. From Suez, caravans picked up the merchandise to carry it to Cairo or Alexandria. From Basra, likewise, caravans picked up goods to take to either Aleppo or Tripoli (Lebanon). At these Mediterranean ports, merchants from the European mainland would take charge of the goods. The Venetians dominated this part of the transaction, but there were many others besides them who were engaged in the trade under separate treaties with the Ottoman and Egyptian rulers. Turks, Muslims, Ragusans of Dubrovnik, Armenians, and Greeks each had a share in the business. Southern Europeans dominated shipping and worked as mercenaries in the Mamluk army. The relationship of the southern Europeans with the major states was sufficiently secure for the Europeans to consider collaborative projects to dig a Suez Canal c. 1500.[2] Had they succeeded in that endeavor, the history of the world might have been different.

Distinct communities of merchant-mariners operated the ships and formed the main component of the Indian port towns – in Cambay, the Gujarati Muslims; in Malabar, the Mapilla Muslims; in Coromandel, the Chulia merchants and the Telugu Chettis of the Balija and Komati communities, and in eastern India, the Oriyas and Bengalis. Some of these were mainly merchants, others mainly shipowners and merchants on the side. In each case, mercantile enterprise was linked to a local shipbuilding tradition as well. Of these groups, the Gujarati may have experienced a significant expansion in the scale of their business in the fifteenth century because of the cessation of direct Arab-China trade. They were sufficiently mobile to make use of the opportunity, settling themselves in Malacca and Aden, and forging closer ties between West Asia and Cambay. The Coromandel and Bengal trade was comparatively smaller

[2] Nicholas Mirkovich, "Ragusa and the Portuguese Spice Trade," *Slavonic and East European Review* 2(1), 1943, pp. 174–87.

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in size and less affected. The main Coromandel port was Pulicat, which was one of the principal connectors between the Vijayanagar Empire and the eastern Indian Ocean. In Bengal, Saptagram and Chittagong conducted trade with Burma, Indonesia, and China. All of these ports, moreover, participated actively in the port-to-port coastal trade. Ships from Bengal bound for the Red Sea would routinely halt at Konkan or at Cambay or in the Maldives.

None of these ports was firmly linked to an inland empire. The states that earned an income from them were relatively small and only locally influential. The Samudri king ruled a small state from Calicut, Cambay had its own king, and many small ports along the Konkan coast were ruled by chieftains. In the east, the authority of the sultan of Gaud on the Chittagong port was substantial, but the authority of his court became shaky in the 1530s after Mughal and Afghan expansion in the west. One consequence of this change was the struggle for control over Chittagong among the Portuguese, the Arakanese, and, later, the Mughals. The commercial operators in these ports, therefore, needed to adapt to pan-regional economic or political tendencies rather than try to control and shape these forces.

The equilibrium was upset with the growth of two ports. One of these, Masulipatnam, was in Coromandel, and its rise was associated with the power of the Qutb Shahi rule in Golkonda. Conveniently located, the port could serve Southeast Asia, Bengal, and the Gulf trades, and it quickly became home to Persian merchants. Located on the estuary of the Krishna in a fertile cultivated plain, it could become a victualing stop. Ship building and repair as well as skilled artisanal production were also attracted to the region. The second port of importance in the early seventeenth century was Surat, in Gujarat. Surat had shared in the improved fortunes of Gujarati trading enterprises in the fifteenth century but had remained overshadowed by Cambay. Surat's status as a competing hub was a threat to Portuguese designs to control West Asian trade, and, therefore, the Portuguese sacked the port city in 1530. A slow consolidation of trade began again in the second half of the sixteenth century, but it was only after the annexation of Gujarat by the Mughal Empire in 1576 that Surat came to be treated as a vital asset. A strong yet semi-independent administration was set up to manage the port's commercial policy and taxation.

In the sixteenth century, the Portuguese enterprise operated from Goa, Cambay, Cochin, and Bengal. A century later, the Dutch and the English avoided sites where the chance of a direct confrontation with the Portuguese was increased. Initially, the Dutch and the English operated

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from Surat and Masulipatnam. Their pattern of shifting the sites of their ports to safer and more secure port towns was taken to new heights in the second half of the seventeenth century, when the English moved their base to Bombay, Madras, and Calcutta.

The Portuguese enterprise

On August 14, 1415, Ceuta, a port city located on the northwestern corner of the African continent, fell to a Portuguese navy of forty-five thousand men. The Portuguese expedition had been more religious than economic in intent. Nevertheless, Ceuta, "the key of the Mediterranean," as well as a key to the West African littoral, was a valuable commercial asset. Ceuta's capture made it feasible for the Portuguese to launch more ambitious expeditions down the Atlantic in search of mythical Christian lands, as well as gold, silver, and spices.

In a curious way, the Portuguese situation created the will to and the capability for undertaking long-distance maritime voyages of uncertain prospects. The exact combination of events, conditions, and preparations that led to such expeditions form the subject of endless discussion. So does the question of exactly when these voyages had began. Portugal was one of the poorest nations in Europe. And yet, its people had strong navigation skills. Some of the early raiding parties were already equipped so that they could leave sight of the coast. Royal patronage also contributed to this naval capability. Moreover, the poverty of the nobility and the high mortality of the population made maritime expedition a feasible way to make a living. This drive to find secure livelihoods partly explains why the early fifteenth-century expeditions were short-distance ones. Settlements of colonist farmers, fishermen, traders, and slavers were established in each new place before the next move happened. In each instance, the regular exchange of information between those in charge of the naval missions and the sailors who had already ventured beyond the known limits of the sea meant that the next exploration would go further. The vessels' small size – even Vasco da Gama's India trip included ships that were barely 200–250 tons – helped longer expeditions by requiring frequent stops. In this fashion, the Portuguese extended their presence from Ceuta to Tangier, Madeira, Cape Verde, Guinea, Senegal, and Ghana between 1415 and 1480.

In the 1480s, an adventurous overland private journey to Sofala, a port town on the Mozambique coast, and the expedition of Bartholomew Diaz,

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which circumnavigated Africa to a little beyond the Cape of Good Hope, created sufficient knowledge of the western Indian Ocean to make a trip to India look both promising and possible to undertake. Commercial interest in India at the time was almost monopolized by Venetian merchants. The main traffic in Indian goods made the relatively short journey across the Arabian Sea to reach the Persian Gulf, where caravans would take the cargo to a Mediterranean port, and onward to Europe. Although the Portuguese court was not in complete agreement on the wisdom of cutting out the Venetian traders in the event that a sea route to Asia could be found, the group that wanted to press the advantage given Portugal by the Diaz voyage prevailed. The nobleman Vasco da Gama was named leader of the India mission. Da Gama had battle and navigational experience, but he was probably chosen more for his political skills. The mission was to be partly diplomatic in nature, rather than a crusade. After more than three months at sea, followed by a series of stops, the fleet reached the east coast of Africa, which had an established trade with India. During the several months that the fleet explored the east coast harbors, friendly contacts were established with many local kings, but the first stirrings of religious hostility also occurred. A Gujarati pilot picked up in Mombasa steered the fleet to Calicut in May 1498.

The fleet's experience on the Malabar coast was a mixed one. Its attempt to trade was not very successful, which da Gama attributed to the resistance of Muslim merchants. But he did return to Portugal, after a voyage that saw many sailors die in transit, with a consignment of cinnamon, cloves, pepper, nutmeg, and precious stones. More valuable than the cargo was the knowledge of navigating the Arabian Sea that da Gama brought back with him. However, it was really da Gama's second visit to Calicut, in 1502–3, that defined the pattern of Portuguese expansion to follow. That voyage resulted in a number of treaties giving the Portuguese permission to trade, but it also left in its wake horrific excesses that included the bombardment of Calicut and the massacre of passengers on a ship bound for Mecca.

When the expedition by Afonso de Albuquerque took place the next year, the aim was to create dominions and colonies rather than diplomatic missions. In little more than a decade, settlements were established in Ceylon and Goa; Cochin and Cannanore became friendly states, and Malacca and Hormuz were subdued into treaty ports. Martaban in Burma opened its doors, and a powerful allied fleet commanded by the Mamluks was routed in Diu. This last challenge was more or less engineered by the Venetian merchants who had been worried about the competition from the Cape route and had been working toward a military

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solution for some time. Aden held out, but only just. Portugal's longer-term objective, redirecting the Asian spice trade from the Mediterranean route to the Cape route, was within reach.

In the first half of the sixteenth century, Portuguese maritime trade focused on the western Indian littoral. Although the capture of Malacca had broadened the sphere of trading operations and, especially, had made it easier for the Portuguese to explore the eastern Indian Ocean, Bengal and Orissa were not an official priority for them as much as was the spice route. The Crown took a great interest in the trade and made the trade by the Cape route a monopoly of Casa da India, a Crown trading firm. The Estado da India, which was based in Goa, was the Crown's representative in the second half of the century. The main interest of the Casa da India was in trading as much Indonesian spices as possible without mediation. Simultaneously, the state tried to obstruct the West Asia trade route – destroying some Arab shipping in the process and collecting protection money from the other Arab firms – and to redirect Indonesian trade to the Cape route. To exert its control, the Estado da India, in exchange for a small fee, issued passes to any ship that wanted to ply the Indian Ocean. It was obligatory for the pass holder to pay customs at a port under Portuguese control. The authority of Goa was represented in the waters by the captains of the vessels that belonged to the king. But the business of collecting protection money was also informally carried out by sea captains and private traders, and not only on this route.

Why was the Portuguese enterprise especially prone to use of force? In the rather special circumstances of the early sixteenth century, when the Portuguese wanted to oust the Muslim merchants in the spice trade of Malabar and Sumatra, violence became a necessary weapon. A crusading impulse may have made the conflict worse. When that phase had passed, the strategy of firing one's way into the Indian Ocean was no longer either necessary or successful. But in the first half of the century, the violent attempts paid off. The Portuguese intervention saw pepper prices stabilize in Europe after a fall in the late 1400s.[3] Profits were sustained at high levels, possibly several hundred percent. Lisbon almost became an entrepôt, although the city was hardly ready for that honor. Because of the limitations of Lisbon, much wholesale trade was diverted to the Flemish free port of Antwerp. Though the Netherlands was located in the thick of the European spice trade, dependence on Portugal was odious to the Dutch provinces, which were at war with Spain and Portugal. This situation

[3] Frederic C. Lane, "Pepper Prices before Da Gama," *Journal of Economic History* 28(4), 1968, pp. 590–97.

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eventually supplied one of the motivations for the formation of the Dutch East India Company in 1602.

The first half of the 1500s saw some disturbance in the Persian Gulf trade. The Portuguese controlled Hormuz, taking a commanding position in the Gulf route. A series of diplomatic and naval expeditions had established the Portuguese as the most powerful players in Malacca on the Malaysian coast, Nagasaki in Japan, Macau off China, Goa and Diu in Konkan, and Cochin in Malabar. With this ring of fortified settlements in place, and their partners, the Spanish, stationed in Manila, the Iberians could think of a system for the command and control of the Indian Ocean. In the short-term, the affected parties were the West Asian traders. In the long run, the situation led to European conflicts that spilled over from the Atlantic into the Indian Ocean, as we shall see. The political situation turned murky when the Turks invaded territories of the Mamluk sultans (1516–17) and when the Venetians fought with the Turks in 1537–40. On the whole, however, local participants seemed to reconcile themselves to Portuguese power in the region, paid taxes, and carried on as before. In the second half of the century, the Levantine route, especially the shorter and easier one over Mesopotamia, revived. Politics apart, an overland journey was safer than a sea one. And Portuguese attempts at enforcing the monopoly had begun to fail.

The Portuguese Crown began to farm out its authority to private merchants and sea captains early in the second half of the sixteenth century. This was a time when the attempts to control long-distance maritime routes along these routes faced serious challenges from rivals and were being given up. Southeast Asian supplies of pepper slipped through Portuguese controls into Venetian hands from as early as the 1560s. Interestingly, shipping volumes via the Cape did not immediately respond to this failure. The data show that the number of ships plying the route between Lisbon and India fell continuously in the sixteenth century, whereas the average tonnage carried increased. In the end, the total annual volume held steady in 1500–1600 (4,000–5,000 tons Lisbon departures), increased somewhat in 1600–1620 (6,000–7,700 tons), and declined steadily and sharply thereafter.[4] By 1650, annual volume leaving Lisbon for Asia was less than two thousand tons.

During the earlier part of this trajectory, the Crown's involvement in the trade was in retreat, but private Portuguese traders increased their participation. The work of James Boyajian supplies "evidence of the riches and

[4] Cited in Prakash, *European Commercial Enterprise*, p. 32.

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sophistication of private Portuguese trade within Asia."[5] On the long-distance route, the private actors included members of the so-called New Christian community, Jewish groups who had converted to Christianity. Along with these people, *casados*, or settlers, also entered private coast-to-coast trade. Based in Bengal and Goa, they carried bulk goods such as sugar or rice, connecting Bengal with the Orissa coast, where Pipli had emerged to become a port of call, and eastern India with southern India, Ceylon, and Hormuz.

After 1640, the forces of decline seemed to prevail in Portuguese commerce more generally. The territorial empire in South Asia ended up as a small, impoverished, and economically insignificant settlement based in Goa, leaving the Dutch and the English East India Companies in command of the commercial heights. Historians have debated whether the failure of the Portuguese enterprise was economic or political. In one view, the ultimate failure was due to the "redistributive" and "precapitalist" nature of the enterprise. It lived off the profits of others rather than make its own activities profitable.[6] In another view, the Portuguese commercial empire ended not because of its own premodern outlook but because of external factors, including the resistance of strong territorial states such as those under the Mughals, Ottomans, Japanese, and Persians.[7] By the time later European actors displayed a propensity to colonize land in India, some of these territorial states had become weaker.

The Bengal seaboard presents conditions quite different from those of the western coast of India. By the middle decades of the sixteenth century, a substantial number of Portuguese were present in Bengal as private traders, mercenaries, artillerymen, and shipwrights.[8] The fragmented political authority after the Mughal invasion in 1595, as well as the rising ambitions of Arakan, created a whole new political prospect in the region. The Bengal story revolves around two towns, Hooghly and Sandwip. In

[5] James Boyajian, *Portuguese Trade in Asia under the Habsburgs, 1580–1640*, Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 2007, p. xiii.

[6] Niels Steensgaard, *The Asian Trade Revolution of the Seventeenth Century: The East India Companies and the Decline of the Caravan Trade*, Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1974.

[7] For a discussion, see M.N. Pearson, *The Portuguese in India*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1987; Sanjay Subrahmanyam, *The Portuguese Empire in Asia, 1500–1700: A Political and Economic History*, London and New York: Longman, 1993; and Sanjay Subrahmanyam, *The Career and Legend of Vasco da Gama*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press. 1997.

[8] Sanjay Subrahmanyam, "Notes on the Sixteenth-Century Bengal Trade," *Indian Economic Social History* Review 24(3), 1987, pp. 265–89.

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both places, the Mughal provincial administration suspected the Portuguese of river piracy. Although for a long time the Mughals were not strong enough to oust or suppress the Portuguese in Sandwip, they did succeed in doing so in Hooghly.

Sebastiao Gonzales was the most famous example of the opportunism and ambition exhibited by members of the loosely constituted community on the Bengal seaboard. A salt trader, Gonzales was in the company of a small band of refugees from Arakan who had rearmed themselves and befriended the king of Bakla, a seacoast state, in the last decade of the fifteenth century. Gonzales was their commander. Buttressed by boats and horses from Bakla, and with timely help from a Spanish fleet as well as some subterfuge, Gonzales captured Sandwip from the Mughals in 1607. He thereupon reneged on his promises to Bakla to share the Sandwip revenues, established a customshouse, and received respectful mention in Mughal sources. When the threat of a Mughal counterattack materialized after a few years, Gonzales planned a joint campaign with the Arakan king but withdrew from it, leaving the Arakan navy to face a rout. The Arakans retaliated, and Gonzales sought help from the viceroy at Goa. The viceroy sent a symbolic fleet in aid of an unreliable ally. Eventually, Portuguese mismanagement of the campaign, the death of the commander of the Goa fleet, the sudden appearance of a Dutch fleet that used the Portuguese fleet for target practice, and the appearance of a large ebb tide that cut the Portuguese fleet in half combined to bring about a Portuguese defeat. The Goa fleet refused to engage further, and in 1616, the Arakan king captured Sandwip. The Portuguese commercial presence in the Indian Ocean rapidly declined shortly after this episode. Although this decline was in the main caused by other factors, Portuguese misadventures in the Bay of Bengal played no small part in it. In the meantime, the English and the Dutch East India Companies had entrenched themselves on the western Indian Ocean.

East India Companies: Origins

A number of circumstances induced the merchants of the City of London to form an overseas trading company in the last years of the 1500s. The sixteenth century had ended in England in a curious combination of static trade and rising ambitions. Almost all of the shipping engaged in the European trade was foreign owned. Joint-stock companies were in existence, for example, the Levant Company and the Venice Company; neither

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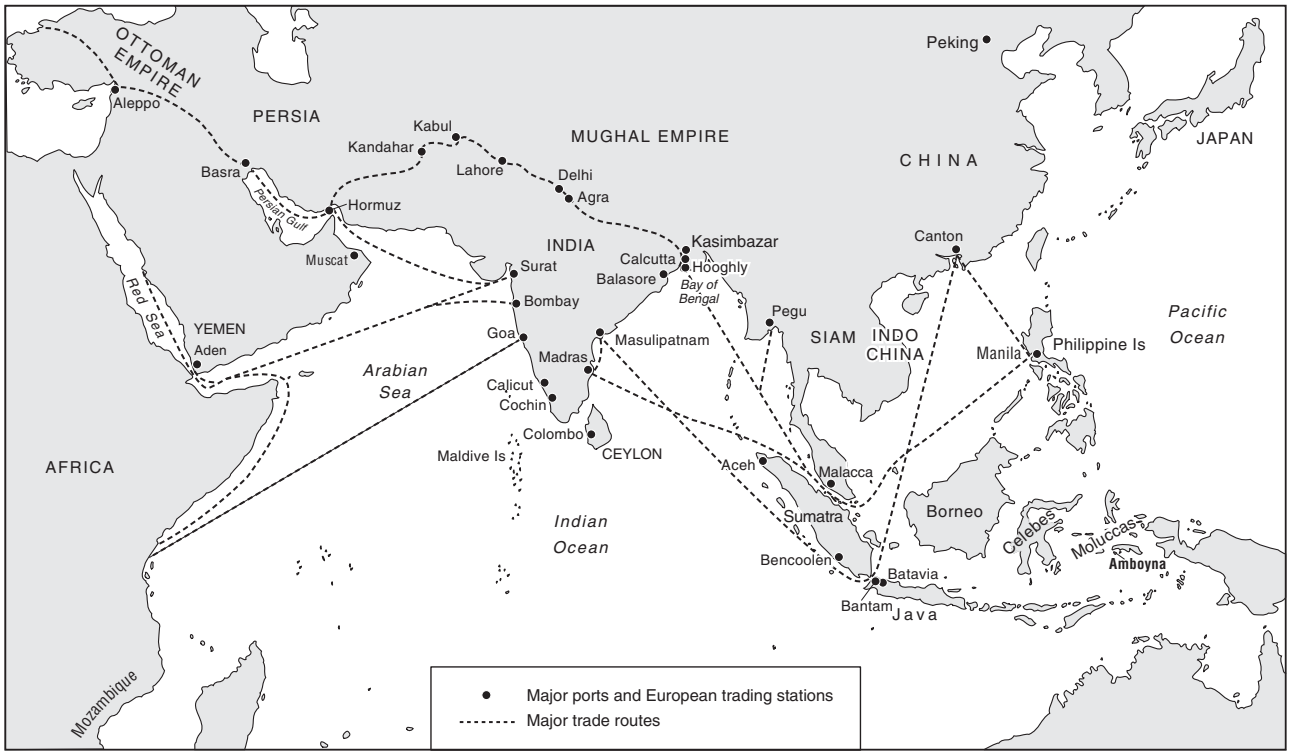


4.1. Wall hanging (cotton) showing early traders to India, late sixteenth century. *Source*: The Bridgeman Art Library

of these did much business, however, and, on the whole, the joint-stock companies failed to break the stranglehold that southern European merchants maintained over the overland traffic with Asia. The destruction of Antwerp in 1576 by Spanish forces led to a redirection of trade, but, according to Lawrence Stone, no great change in trade volumes.[9] Nevertheless, English shipping did see an expansion and reorganization after this event, and it acquired more flexibility in the last half of Elizabeth's reign. The other event in the commercial arena that contributed to a reorganization was the end to the long-festering conflict between the English merchants operating in Central Europe and the Hanseatic League merchants operating in London who enjoyed preferential trading rights in England but resisted extending reciprocal privileges to the English

[9] Lawrence Stone, "Elizabethan Overseas Trade," *Economic History Review* 2(1), 1949, pp. 30–58.

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4.2. Maritime routes and ports with European presence, c. 1650.

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in Europe. The suspension of immunities or withdrawal of special privileges (1578) and the eventual expulsion of the league by Elizabeth (1597) encouraged company formation in the City.

More than these external events, Elizabethan London developed a set of conditions that made ambitious overseas exploration more feasible than before. Spices from Malabar and Indonesia were known to Europe in the sixteenth century but had to be procured either from the Portuguese or from Genoese and Venetian merchants and their allies in the Ottoman and Persian Empires. Early overland journeys, such as that made by the Englishman Ralph Fitch, recorded the goods that Europe could buy from India. The predatory expeditions of Francis Drake and Thomas Cavendish exposed the weaknesses of Spanish and Portuguese defenses in the Atlantic and the Pacific. Exploration by Walter Raleigh, Humphrey Gilbert, John Hawkins, and Martin Frobisher increased English knowledge of navigation, brought the existing maps within reach, and created much interest in navigation for commercial purposes. Among the sailors, ship captains, and explorers who attended the meeting at Founders' Hall (Sept. 22, 1599) in London that led to the formation of the English East India Company were both individuals who had acquired their reputations in Atlantic exploration and merchants whose interests straddled the Atlantic Ocean, Africa, and the Levant. Prominent members of the Levant Company were willing to spend money on shipping over the Cape route in order to bypass the Levant route.

These developments bore fruit in 1599–1600. The City merchants, town notables, and members of the fleet of Drake and Frobisher came together to form the Company of the Merchants of London Trading to the East Indies and obtained a royal charter granting them a monopoly in the trade east of the Cape. The terms of the monopoly obliged the company to pay taxes to the Crown, allowed the company to take out bullion but regulated the amount, and made unauthorized trade in the goods that formed the company's staple business punishable by law. In effect, the company held the right to farm out the trade to its shareholders or to "factors" engaged by them, while also hiring employees to conduct its own trade.

The Dutch East India Company followed formation of the English company two years later. In the Dutch provinces, after the fall of Antwerp, the authority of the monarchy was relatively weak and the authority of the city guilds strong. A "deviant medieval heritage" had led to relatively weak seignorial powers, secure and saleable private property in land, and powerful corporate capitalist bodies long before Amsterdam emerged as a leading

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financial center of the world.[10] Much of the Dutch capital and the organization was devoted to shipping, and this field was expanding because of difficulties in obtaining traded goods from southern Europe.

In the late sixteenth century, Dutch ships made relatively short-haul commercial expeditions into the Atlantic. One convoy called on the Cape Verde Islands to procure salt, which was becoming hard to get because of an Iberian blockade. Dutch ships and sailors were also hired by the Portuguese as transporters between Brazil and Europe. Over the next ten years, the pattern of Dutch maritime and commercial journeys was established, with ships going regularly to the West Indies and the Cape of Good Hope and dealing in a more or less fixed set of goods. At least one voyage made it to the Strait of Magellan and the eastern Pacific. Salt hauling continued to be an important aim, but gold, silver, pepper, and possibly slaves joined the cargo.

The Dutch decision to pool capital and consolidate the number of small East India companies into the United Company in 1602, with a monopoly charter, was partly a response to the formation of the English East India Company and partly a response to the problems of securing spices overland. Although it was a joint-stock company representing merchants, the Dutch East India Company was a different kind of firm from its English counterpart, being in the nature of a shipping cartel. In one view, the cartel was less dependent on royal patronage than was the English company; however, a different reading attributes Dutch commercial success in Asian waters to the occasional but critical intervention of state naval power.[11]

Shortly after the formation of the company, Dutch shipping, consisting of large armed vessels of 500–1,000 tons, established itself as a formidable power off the western coast of India and the Indonesian Islands. In the early 1600s, the contest for control of trade in the Atlantic and in Indonesia between the Dutch and the Spanish was fierce and only occasionally contained by diplomatic efforts. By 1630, Dutch power was the main factor behind the disarray that beset Portuguese trade in India and Indonesia. Dutch power in Indonesia was also the factor that led the English to concentrate on India and to use diplomatic missions to the Mughal court to obtain trade treaties. In this enterprise, the English went further than the other western Europeans.

[10] Jan de Vries, "On the Modernity of the Dutch Republic," *Journal of Economic History* 33(1), 1973, pp. 191–202.

[11] Jonathan I. Israel, *Dutch Primacy in World Trade, 1585–1740*, Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1989.

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Of the major maritime nations in Western Europe, the French were the last to enter the race for the East Indies. An early French enterprise set up in 1604 for this purpose and protected by a royal monopoly dissipated its energies in infighting. Inevitably, rivals offered their services to the court, and a new enterprise formed in 1615. The first voyage of this firm to Java ended in a failure. Nothing more happened in the next twenty years except for an attempt to set up a trading station and settlement in Madagascar. When La Compagnie des Indes was reconstituted in 1642, its first missions were to explore Madagascar. India became a priority much later.

In 1661, Jean-Baptiste Colbert took over the reins of the French treasury. A merchant and banker by family background and training, Colbert immediately set out to expand the French navy and acquire and develop ports. Along with meeting his nation's defense needs, Colbert had his eyes on strengthening overseas commercial exploration. In 1664, a new *compagnie* formed under his initiative. When missions to India were again organized, the French could use their existing bases in Madagascar quite effectively. However, conflict with the Dutch during the Nine Years' War (1688–97) in Europe made French presence in the Indian region shaky again. It was not until 1700 that the French established a secure foothold in India. Thereafter, even as France was engulfed in a financial crisis and the French company underwent many changes at home, the Indian mission survived and was consistently profitable.

The company form and its problems

English and Dutch overseas trading was organized quite differently from the state-sponsored Portuguese ventures. The joint-stock form of both companies reduced the danger of bankruptcy. The monopoly charter that the English East India Company carried reduced its risk of competition from other Englishmen. But perhaps the most important effect of the representation of trade by a single firm was that the company could send credible diplomatic missions to the courts in India seeking a license to trade. These peaceful missions might not have succeeded without a series of victories that the English scored over the Portuguese off the Konkan between 1610 and 1640. Still, the element of diplomacy did set the English apart from the Portuguese in the manner in which both powers earned concessions to trade in India. Nevertheless, neither of these organizational innovations – the company form and the diplomatic embassy – was an effective solution to three problems that plagued the English East

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India Company almost from its beginning in 1600 until the end of its trading career in India in 1813.

First, the monopoly charter was difficult to enforce with the company's resources. This was because of competition from City merchants who envied the success of the company and tried to form rival firms. The joint-stock concept did succeed in pulling in private capital from a large number of investors, but the management of the company was restricted to an oligarchy of big shareholders. The opaque management and the constant attacks on monopoly, which took on ideological overtones in the eighteenth century, made the English East India Company's career controversial and mired the firm in numerous allegations of corruption. The outsiders sought to create a lobby within Parliament to seek an end to the company's monopoly, and both sides made use of the stormy relationship between the Crown and Parliament in the middle decades of the seventeenth century. On two occasions the Crown granted charters to rival East India Companies, which did not survive. Even when the company's charter was not under threat, entrepreneurial figures like the merchant Thomas Pitt managed to establish their own trading empires in India in open defiance of the company. In distant India, private trade was a source of irritation between the company and the local kings. To catch the private traders and prosecute them, the company needed the help of the local police. But the kings were loath to be seen to favor the company over the other European traders in their realms. Bribes, therefore, were generously paid to preempt competition from interlopers. By the second half of the eighteenth century, as the Mughal Empire fragmented into a number of regional states, only a semblance of an agreement between the English East India Company and the Mughal court was still working.

Second, the company faced a threat of encroachment from within the establishment. This threat came from the private trading of company employees. The whole enterprise of overseas voyages succeeded by allowing the peripatetic employees some freedom to carry out private trade, but it was impossible to restrain them from overstepping the limits and poaching on the employers' interests. The fact that many of the employees were drawn from among mariners and soldiers whereas company principals were sedentary merchants made their mutual suspicion even more likely. Private trade created a host of complications in the overseas branches of the East India Company. Conflicts of interest were so rife as to be beyond any means of regulation. The officers spied on each other, engaged the company's Indian agents to serve the officers' private interests, and appropriated common resources for their own

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profit. The more powerful and capable the officer, the greater was the conflict of interest. Consequently, the more powerful and capable the officer was, the greater was the likelihood of a disciplinary proceeding against him.

Third, the diplomatic embassies that the English East India Company sent to India were not totally effective. Their effectiveness was limited because the writ from the Mughals did not cover South India and an agreement with a Mughal emperor could be obstructed, if not challenged, by the local administrators of Surat or Hooghly. Also quite serious were two issues that would crop up regularly in the relationship between a local king and company officers. The agreement stipulated the payment of customs based on trade volume. The company head office, however, indicated to the officers that they could try to bribe officials to escape paying the full amount of the taxes. But bribery raised the perennial difficulty that with every change of administrator a fresh agreement had to be made. In addition to taxation, a field of potential dispute was seignorial right, or the right to have a mint on Indian soil. The company imported gold and silver for the payment of Indian goods, but it did not have the right to convert these metals into coins. Conversion was expensive and entailed a dependence on Indian bankers.[12] Despite these difficulties, however, the trade remained exceedingly profitable, and its scale became larger in the 1700s compared to the 1600s.

Scale of trade, 1600–1800

Across two hundred years, the commodities prominent in the basket of imports and the volumes traded did not remain static. The changes reflected the consumer boom in Western Europe that moved from one good to another, the shifting advantages of the overseas branches, and the growing interdependence between the European conquest and the settlement of America, the African slave trade, and the importation of Asian luxuries. Asian import into Europe was dominated by spices in the first half of the seventeenth century; by Indian cotton textiles, saltpeter, and Chinese silk and porcelain in the next one hundred years; and by Chinese tea in the second half of the eighteenth century. The major article in the English East India Company's imports of about 1700 was cotton cloth.

[12] These points are more fully elaborated in Tirthankar Roy, *The East India Company: The World's Most Powerful Corporation*, New Delhi: Allen Lane, 2012.

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Saltpeter, an ingredient in gunpowder, was also in great demand in war-ridden Europe.[13]

Although plain cotton was initially a means of payment in Indian Ocean trade, colored cottons from India were wanted for fashionable clothing and even began to define design standards in apparel.[14] Chinese tea had been introduced into Europe early in the seventeenth century, but it was still an expensive article. Imports increased rapidly in the eighteenth century when supplies steadied. By then, tea was the leading Asian consumer good in the markets of Europe and North America, and the main business interest of the English company. However, this picture neglects commodity flows within the Indian Ocean region that facilitated the Europe-Asia trade. Thus for a brief period in the seventeenth century, Persian horses went to India to balance the trade. Moreover, the Dutch had discovered that Indian cottons were a handy means of payment for spices in Indonesia. One article that sold well in exchange for slaves was, again, Indian cotton cloth.

Among the other Indian goods traded, silk was of some importance in the mid-eighteenth century. The English and the Dutch companies conducted the most business in Bengal in the eighteenth century, at the cost of all other settlements in India. One of the attractions of Bengal was the availability of a portfolio of valuable exports – cotton cloth, opium, saltpeter, sugar, and silk. Bengal was long the major producer in India of raw silk and silk manufactures. From the middle decades of the century, silk occupied a critical part of the English company's exports.[15] The Dutch had been selling Bengal silk in Japan in the seventeenth century, and that market having become uncertain, they found an alternative market in Europe. The new opportunity, however, was frustrated by

[13] On the history of the English and the Dutch companies, see K. N. Chaudhuri, *The Trading World of Asia and the English East India Company, 1660–1760*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1978; Holden Furber, *John Company at Work: A Study of European Expansion in India in the Late Eighteenth Century*, Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1948; Tapan Raychaudhuri, *Jan Company in Coromandel, 1605–1690: A Study in the Interrelations of European Commerce and Traditional Economies*, The Hague: Martinus Nijhoff, 1962; Om Prakash, *European Commercial Enterprise in Pre-colonial India*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1998.

[14] On Indian textiles especially, essays in two recent collections are state of the art: Giorgio Riello and Prasannan Parthasarathi, eds., *The Spinning World: A Global History of Cotton Textiles, 1200–1850*, Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2010; Giorgio Riello and Tirthankar Roy, eds., *How India Clothed the World: The World of South Asian Textiles, 1500–1850*, Leiden: Brill, 2010.

[15] Chaudhuri, *Trading World of Asia and the English East India Company*, pp. 343–58.

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protectionist moves at home, and the Dutch company never quite regained the ground it had lost in Japan.[16]

Interestingly, the volume of European trade in Bengal silk was relatively small in the total business in goods; exports of Bengal silk by the English and the Dutch did not exceed 150 tons annually in the 1730s. By comparison, in the 1750s, Asian merchants exported by land five times as much as the volume that the Europeans carried.[17] Indeed, the dominance of North Indian merchants was so strong that the Europeans could never gain an advantageous position in this trade. The volume of the trade was in decline in the second half of the century because of political uncertainty in northern India and disease that attacked the silkworms. By 1820, when Asian silk export to Europe exceeded 500 tons, Bengal occupied a negligible share.

The New World contributed to the Asian trades indirectly by strengthening the European consumer boom. Virginia tobacco in the middle decades of the seventeenth century and Caribbean sugar in the eighteenth century were the most important American goods shaping consumption demand. Furthermore, profits from the sugar trade were reinvested in building ports, docks, banks, and insurance in London, and in the slave trade in West Africa. Indian textiles were used as means of payment in Africa for slaves, in turn feeding into production for export to the Americas. But more than anything else, it was silver from the Americas that contributed to the making of Asian trade. The Spanish conquest had made silver progressively cheaper in Europe than in China and India. These circumstances, together with the almost inexhaustible demand for silver as a private asset in India, made it possible to continue the purchases of Asian goods until the mid-eighteenth century.[18]

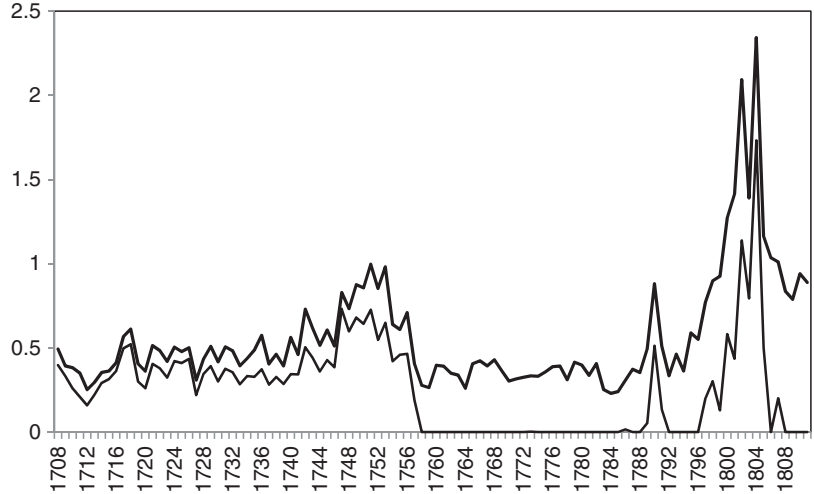
The success of silver as a means of payment was not owed just to the metal's elastic supply. Money was more expensive in Asia than in Europe, a difference that derived from the structure of the respective financial systems. The sustained dependence of the trade on liquid rather than on borrowed capital as soon as the traders reached Asian shores stemmed from the exorbitant real interest rates that borrowing in Asia entailed.

[16] Els M. Jacobs, *Merchant in Asia: The Trade of the Dutch East India Company during the Eighteenth Century*, Leiden: Brill, 2006, pp. 109–15.

[17] Sushil Chaudhury, "International Trade in Bengal Silk and the Comparative Role of Asians and Europeans, circa.1700–1757," *Modern Asian Studies* 29(2), 1995, pp. 373–86.

[18] André Gunder Frank, *ReOrient: Global Economy in the Asian Age*, Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California Press, 1998; Dennis O. Flynn and Arturo Giráldez, "Cycles of Silver: Global Economic Unity through the Mid-Eighteenth Century," *Journal of World History* 13(2), 2002, pp. 391–427.

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4.3. Import of bullion and goods (m £) by the English East India Company into India, 1708–1810. *Source*: British Parliamentary Papers, 1812–13 (152), *An account of Bullion and Merchandize*.

Only late in the eighteenth century did English irons and iron goods like cannons and guns begin to sell well in India, reducing the dependence on silver somewhat. Again from late in the eighteenth century, Indian opium was found to be a convenient means of payment for Chinese tea, freeing the Europe-India trade, if fitfully, from the bonds of silver.

Given the overwhelming dependence on silver, a rough measure of the volume of the business would be the total value of silver and of goods imported into India. The relevant data for the English East India Company are presented in Figure 4.3. The real volume of the textile trade did not in fact change much between 1700 and 1800. The slow rise in the value largely reflects the rising prices of textiles in the first sixty years of the time series. There was a structural break point in the middle of the century. Trade dropped abruptly, and silver inflow stopped almost completely. This break was a result of the political developments of the time, to which I will return. In the mid-eighteenth century, the English East India Company was the leader of the market, with roughly 50 percent market share in textiles; the French and the Dutch shared the remaining half. The English, however, were a smaller player in the Coromandel, though they were dominant in Bengal. The late eighteenth-century decline in fortunes was experienced by all of them. One common unfavorable factor was the

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rise of private traders and American competition. But political and military rivalry in India also drained the resources of the competing powers. While the French and the Dutch East India Companies ended their careers, the English company continued, but only by reinventing itself as a colonial power.

Partners, employees, agents

How much did European trade depend on Indian institutions and agents? By the benchmarks of premodern trade, the Asian trading organization was efficient, dynamic, adaptive, and capable of responding to opportunity. In the beginning, as the trade historian Om Prakash points out, "the Europeans had no option but to operate within the given organizational structure."[19] This "given organizational structure" included accommodation by bankers and money changers, partnerships with local merchants, and the services of artisans and shipwrights. The Indian employees of the European companies deserve little comment, for the major part of the business was conducted with the help of merchants who worked on commission. Nevertheless, in the eighteenth century, some individuals engaged on salary did perform a politically useful service for the company, namely, spying on the affairs of and on occasion negotiating with the princely courts. Also, as we will see, the reliance on salaried employees tended to increase in the late eighteenth century, partly on account of long-standing problems in contract enforcement.

It is useful to remind ourselves how dependent Indo-European trade was on Asian traders. The latter retained control over almost all aspects of Indo-European business except the final sale and shipment by sea. They functioned not only as agents and middlemen for the Europeans inside India but also as the principal actors in overland trade, in transactions between Indian regions, and in transactions between Indian Ocean regions. All forms of caravan trade and the markets where caravan goods came to be sold were dominated by the Indians. River-borne trade likewise was controlled by the Indians. Pedro Machado has recently pointed to "the resourcefulness and dynamism of indigenous merchants and capital in exploiting markets in the Indian Ocean." Machado's work shows how the Gujarati traders supplied cotton textiles

[19] Prakash, *European Commercial Enterprise*, p. 4.

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produced in Gujarat to Portuguese Mozambique in the last quarter of the eighteenth century and established an import trade in African ivory in the process.[20] In this scenario, there could be no question of Europeans' achieving dominance over trading institutions. Their goal was rather to build stable and productive partnerships. As this section will show, the road to such partnerships was not an easy one.

Of the individuals who supplied useful services to the European companies in India, a rough distinction can be made between those who sold services for one-off payments and those who were engaged under a more or less permanent contract. Bankers were the principal members of the first group. Interest rates were higher than in Europe even for reliable clients. The terms of duration for loans were shorter on average, which is evident from the many interest rates quoted by the month. The major component in the demand for money was financing revenue payments and the grain trade after harvests, so that interest rates varied greatly by the season. To finance the purchase of manufactures, therefore, a company needed to choose the lender and the time of borrowing carefully. The major reason for depending on the banker, however, was to convert silver bullion into coins with high silver content. So lucrative was this business that occasionally local rulers and princes joined in. Using their legal monopoly on coinage, they could try to increase the profits from minting coins or exchanging currency.

As the Mughal dominion shrank in the eighteenth century, and new powers emerged, the business of the conversion of one local currency into another increased in importance. Money changing entailed risks. Since almost all currencies were metallic, the exchange rate between them was related to the intrinsic value of the currencies' metal content. Bankers ascertained the intrinsic value and decided the fair exchange rate. The greater the diversity of the coins, the more information and trust was needed in this exchange. But information was not always adequate, and trust could fail, with the result that sometimes bankers refused to accept a coin from another region, or they released money that was debased and that the bazaar refused to accept. When this problem became serious in the eighteenth century, the East India Company moved to solve it. Payments of money from one of its branches to another were effected by means of promissory notes purchased from one branch of a banking firm

[20] Pedro Machado, "A Regional Market in a Globalised Economy: East Central and South Eastern Africans, Gujarati Merchants and the Indian Textile Industry in the Eighteenth and Nineteenth Centuries," in Riello and Roy, *How India Clothed the World*, pp. 53–84 (quote on p. 83).

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and redeemable at another branch or in another town. The dependence on bankers continued, if in a different form.

After the English company assumed power in Bengal, the great banking firms of northern India suffered a mixed fate. Some of them, such as the Jagatseths of Bengal, were no longer necessary to the new regime, which centralized its main monetary functions. The company's custom in the remittance business was a source of prosperity for other firms, however, such as Gopaldas of Benares and Arjunji Nathji of Surat. As borrowing was often used in the late eighteenth century to finance war, the indigenous bankers who were allied with the English company were regarded as friends of the regime. These houses had agents in nearly all major commercial towns of northern and western India. They were connected through a system of intelligence unmatched by the government in efficiency. Therefore, bankers were often relied on for military intelligence.

Indian maritime trading communities were entrenched in the coastal trade. In Gujarat, Malabar, and Coromandel, they owned boats and conducted trade. Although owning their capital, sometimes the coastal communities also hired their services to ship-owning merchants of Bombay. One of the main businesses of these communities was to load cargo and food on ships that sailed from Bombay for Europe. At Calicut, pepper was a common cargo, and timber from Canara was loaded on ships that took it to the East India Company naval yard at Trincomalee. Dhows, which were medium-sized boats of 50–250 tons fitted with a mast and lateen sails, carried coconut and copra from Malabar to Bombay. From the late eighteenth century or a little later, the dhows also carried European manufactures from Bombay to the southern Arabian ports, bringing back on their return dates, wine, and horses. On the Coromandel coast a similar mid-sized boat plied the route between Madras and Ceylon. These boats, called dhoni, could navigate the shallow waters of the Palk Strait that heavier ships could not negotiate.

Although useful to it, some coastal communities had an uneasy relationship with the East India Company. Those with a base in the islands off the main coast were often engaged in piracy. In the 1660s, the Malabar community Mappilahs was described by Jean-Baptiste Tavernier as made up of ruthless pirates and enemies of Christians. When they arrived on the Arab coast, some of the dhows of the Konkan coast were hired to conduct piracy on the Red Sea. They were usually fitted for armed combat, although whether mainly for attack or for defense is not always clear. In the Coromandel, navigators had less to

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fear from predators but did have to adapt to the treacherous postmonsoon climate and sudden shifts in ocean currents in the Bay of Bengal by building smaller and flatter boats. Much coastal trade, therefore, was left to local interests.[21]

The purchase of goods depended essentially on the Indian contracting merchants. They procured cloth and other supplies from the producers and the bazaars, usually after receiving advances from the company. The typical system in the late seventeenth century was for the merchants to bring samples of cloth to the factories, and then to receive orders and collect the advances. In the early eighteenth century, knowledge about cloth types was sufficiently stable and advanced for the factories to wait for samples. Orders were then placed directly via chief agents or brokers.

Between 1650 and 1750, then, the commercial relationship between the Indian agents and the European factors underwent a change. There was a tendency to expand the scale of contractual purchases and a preference for elevating a few men as the principal contractors or brokers above the others. Based on available biographies, it seems that in the seventeenth century, the principal brokers tended to be military and political men, whereas in the eighteenth century their counterparts were more often indigenous merchants. The transformation was a result of the concentration of contracting in the port cities, obviating the need to rely on local armed men to enforce contracts. In part, the change also reflected the much larger scale of the business in the eighteenth century, which needed the help of specialist merchants rather than merely people in possession of military or political power.

The principal brokers of the English, the Dutch, and the French companies administered the distribution of the contracts to an army of undercontractors. As a result, they commanded prestige, power, and credit in the bazaar. The brokers held an information advantage over their principals in knowing where the sources of supply were located. They could speak the local language, and sometimes they colluded with the undercontractors to cheat the companies on quality. Indeed, the brokers were under some pressure to cheat their principals.

As the chief broker for the French in the 1740s, Anandaranga Pillai explained that the broker's job was not an easy one and did not even carry

[21] John Edye, "Description of the Various Classes of Vessels Constructed and Employed by the Natives of the Coasts of Coromandel, Malabar, and Ceylon," *Journal of the Royal Asiatic Society of Great Britain and Ireland*, London: W. Parker, 1834, pp. 1–15.

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enough profit.[22] The broker faced enormous difficulties in keeping his own empire of undercontractors intact and running. Whenever relations soured between the local state and the merchant firms, the broker was in the line of fire from both. Because the European factors neither knew nor wanted to have anything to do with the undercontractors and artisans, the broker's excuses for nonperformance of contracts could never be verified, and therefore could never be believed. For this reason, a relationship of dependence and distrust developed between the indigenous brokers and the European factors. Their unstable relationship also derived from a conflict of interest that was intrinsic to the business of the companies. The brokers were expected to serve both the companies and the private trade of senior employees. But serving the private interests of a company official exposed a broker to unwanted attention from the company directors and rival officers.

The business relationship between the Europeans and their closest Indian partners was, therefore, ridden with contradictions. These could be manifested in suspected or real fraud, oppression, threats, imprisonment, or invective directed at the Indian merchants. Almost all the major Indian brokers we know of seemed to suffer on this account.

Early in the second half of the seventeenth century, the chief broker of the English East India Company in Coromandel was Kasi Viranna, whose help was indispensable to the company in matters of transportation, procurement, and taxation in Madras. And yet, the appointment letter for Streynsham Master, the chief of Coromandel, expressly urged Master to avoid any situation in which "Verona" was entrusted with exclusive contracting powers, "for from thence many inconveniences may arise."[23] A similarly difficult relationship existed between the factors at Balasore and the chief broker in 1670, Khem Chand Shah. Shah found himself squeezed between two masters who were at times hostile to each other, the Mughal governor and the company, and, as a result, his principals questioned his loyalty to the firm. In 1678–79, the broker in Masulipatnam, Kola Venkadri, secretly negotiated with the king of Golkonda; the broker was imprisoned by the English in retaliation. In the 1730s, in Surat, disputes between leading Parsi and Hindu merchants over the brokerage of the company damaged the relationship between the principals and the agents. And, in 1756, Amirchand, the leading broker for the English company in Bengal, conspired to dethrone the reigning nawab, Siraj ud

[22] H. Dodwell, ed., *The Private Diary of Ananda Ranga Pillai*, vols. 1–8, Madras, 1922, vol. 2, p. 156.

[23] Richard Temple, ed., *The Diaries of Streynsham Master, 1675–1680*, London: John Murray, 1911, p. 211.

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Daula. He was suspected by Robert Clive of double-crossing the English and penalized rather than rewarded for his efforts.

In the English East India Company's correspondence, the business relationship between Indians and Europeans was called a "contract" or a "compact," and sometimes disputes that arose between the parties to it was called "breach of contract." These terms had no known Indian counterparts in the context of the sale of goods. Neither the Hindu nor the Islamic code of law recognized contracts and agreements; they dealt mainly with debt rather than with sales. These codes were also too closely tied to religious identity to function as the law of the land (*lex loci*). Indeed, there is no historical evidence that religious strictures were used in an actual court of law. For all we know, the word "contract" was introduced by the Europeans, for the large-scale purchase of a commodity based on an advanced agreement was a form of exchange that had been unknown in India before the arrival of the company. As established by the company, the system of ordering and receiving cloth involved elaborate written contracts between the chiefs of Bombay, Madras, and Calcutta and the merchants and master weavers with whom they worked. These contracts specified quantity, price, dimension, quality, advances, and wages. When goods were delivered to the factory, senior officers examined the cargo, satisfying themselves that the terms of the contract had been fulfilled. In later years, the word "contract" was extended to cover a wide variety of exchanges, such as the promises made by Banjara caravan runners to supply the company's army with grain.

The insistence on a written contract might be surprising given that there was no law in India to deal with breach of contract. What good did a contract do then? In part, the contract made bookkeeping easier. Moreover, the contract served as a kind of moral obligation. Breaking a sales contract, if not exactly punishable under the Islamic law that was in force, was nonetheless condemned as sinful.

In their territorial acquisitions, however, the English company could moderate these transaction costs by introducing different laws. The next section explores how the company acquired its land.

From merchants to landlords: The port towns

With European wars spilling over into the Indian Ocean, all of the merchant companies wanted to construct fortified settlements. The Portuguese had shown the way with a string of forts that combined trade and naval

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4.4. Terracotta panel from an eighteenth-century Bengali temple showing a group of Europeans carrying guns. The temple, the Radha Gobinda temple of Aatpur, is located twenty miles northwest of Calcutta. *Source*: Rangan Datta

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command. In the seventeenth century, the Portuguese lost their hold in Persia, Ceylon, and Bengal. The English, in their turn, had been more or less driven from the Indonesian pepper trade by the Dutch and were keen to strengthen their hold in India. One outcome of this turmoil was the emergence of three small territories that the English East India Company found themselves in secure possession of: Madras (c. 1640), Bombay (c. 1660), and Calcutta (c. 1690).

The purchase of these territories involved potentially violent disputes with local states. Each site came to the English separately, through a process of threatened or actual warfare. And yet, once the threats subsided, each territory emerged not only as a little colony of the company with its own laws and administration but also as a commercial center, a port, and a destination for migrant Indian artisans and merchants. Each site started small, with a tiny European population, a port without a harbor, and a sliver of coastal land where farmers, fishermen, and artisans lived in villages. In each case, a fort and its walls enclosed the factory and the European population; the villages formed a kind of suburb from which supplies of goods and workers came into the fort town. These two worlds transacted their business at arm's length well into the eighteenth century, when a convergence began to take place. In port towns such as Surat, Hooghly, and Masulipatnam, where trading was concentrated, the English merely had the right to live and conduct trade and had to share this right with other European merchant companies and private traders. But in Bombay, Calcutta, and Madras the English were the landlords. This new identity worked in curious ways on both the company's policies in India and the Indian regimes that were warily watching the rise of the company.

The new fort towns represented a growing schism within the East India Company between its London directors, who were City merchants, and the factors, sea captains, and soldiers who managed the affairs of the Indian branches. As we have seen, the company carried out its trading operations by offering to its salaried employees the incentive of conducting trade on their own private accounts. Individuals who had completed indentures would also sometimes join in private trading, as would many sea captains. There was no effective way to make all of these people play by the company's rules, however. The only power that the company had over them was its control over the appointment of senior officers. But here again, the company had to avoid harsh penalties and too much control because the same people who broke trading rules protected the company's assets when these were threatened by the Dutch.

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The formation of the three settlements brought this schism out into the open. The decision to spend money on the forts and cities annoyed the directors. The financial commitments, therefore, were often met from the private resources of the East India Company's senior employees, who were, in turn, indicted for private trading. In this way, George Oxenden and Gerald Aungier, who oversaw Bombay's formative period, faced disgrace. Such was the fate also of Francis Day, who had founded Madras. Job Charnock, an old India hand and the main figure behind Calcutta, was both chastised and praised by the directors. Yet in the presence of immediate threats to the branch offices, the rebel local officers appeared to the towns' populations to be more farsighted than the London directors.

Where did the threats to these settlements come from? The story of Madras began against the backdrop of the Mughal invasion of the Deccan. Similarly, Bombay emerged twenty years later in the wake of threatened attacks on the town by the Maratha warlord Shivaji's army. In the 1680s, the Mughal provincial army in Bengal attacked the English in southern Bengal. The Mughal emperor Aurangzeb left the English alone, however, in the belief that they were too weak to require more than a warning. But the Mughal threats made the European populations in the towns look to the local administrations for protection. The shadow of English politics, especially the conflict between those who supported the monarch (royalists) and those who espoused a republic (radicals), further complicated for the East India Company directors the task of administering the towns. The contest in English politics between the royalists and radicals induced the local administration to claim that they were acting as representatives of the Crown in defying their employers. In 1665, when a local officer, Edward Winter, refused to hand Madras over to the designated representative of the company, and in 1679, when Richard Keigwin, a sea captain, seized power in Bombay, the mutineers posed as royalists. In the end, the company had to come to terms with the autonomy of the towns by giving their governors a wide range of powers, including the power to make laws.

Although the division of power between the Crown and the East India Company was always a messy issue, hindsight suggests that the English company played the game of territorial control more effectively than did the French and the Dutch companies in the days before an empire was even a possibility. However, because the visible success of the English port cities overshadowed the experience of the other Western European settlements, less research has been done on the colonial strategies of the other powers. One exception, a study of Dutch Cochin, suggests that the Dutch, like the English, sought to turn Cochin into a self-financed territory by

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using local and land taxes when the income from its main local merchandise, pepper, became uncertain in the second half of the eighteenth century. To that effect, the small community of Dutch settlers forged new social ties with local and mixed-race families.[24] These moves, however, came to an abrupt end with the suspension of the Dutch company.

Despite their occasional political engagement, until 1740, Bombay, Calcutta, and Madras were little more than trading settlements conducting the routine business of the English East India Company. Although they had grown in naval power and population, there were no structural changes in the character of these towns, and clearly they had not been set up to fight wars with the Indians. But the political situation changed with two developments, the collapse of the Mughal Empire and the rivalry between England and France.

State formation, 1707–1765

In 1707, Aurangzeb, the last of the great Mughal emperors, died. Almost immediately afterward, the empire that had ruled over northern India for 180 years began to collapse and to split into independent states. In this way, Awadh, Hyderabad, and Bengal, formerly Mughal provinces, emerged as independent states, Marathas established dominion over Mughal provinces in central India, and warlords with more localized influence, including the Rajputs and the Nayakas of South India, consolidated their authority.

The Europeans stationed in Bombay, Madras, and Calcutta kept an eye on these upheavals. But the events did not threaten their survival, though they did require more negotiations with the new kings and warlords. Nor was there any indication that the London directors saw the negotiations to be of any strategic importance. If anything, they were as nervous as ever that the territories the company owned in India would be a drain on its profits. Although resenting the costs of fortification and harbor construction, the company head office came to accept the good sense of its having well-defended port cities in India.

And yet the propensity to join in politics was in some way inherent in the organization of the firm. In the middle of the century, local officers increasingly made friends with courtiers and kings and formed partnerships with

[24] Anjana Singh, *Fort Cochin in Kerala, 1750–1830: The Social Condition of a Dutch Community in an Indian Milieu*, Leiden and Boston: Brill, 2010.

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the private traders. Territorial revenues in Calcutta, Madras, and Bombay were from the profits of the resident Indian merchants. In their turn, many of these merchants were refugees from decaying and anarchic states and were more than willing to pay the taxes against the custom of a wealthy port and wealthy business partners. These two lines, the empowerment of merchants and the weakening of states, merged in Bengal and the Carnatic in the 1740s.

In Bengal, repeated Maratha raids in the western districts saw Calcutta emerge as a safe haven for Bengali merchants. When Calcutta was established in 1690, the west bank of the river Hooghly was the more populous and urbanized. The English decision to locate their fort on the east bank of the river was unusual by the conventions of the time. The decision probably depended on the greater navigability of the river toward the east, as well as considerations of defense against the Dutch, the French, the Danish, and the Portuguese settlements, which were all on the west bank. Already by then, a small stream of migration of Bengali textile dealers to the town had begun, especially after the old river port Saptagram had suffered a decline in its fortunes due to silting of the port. This trickle now became a flood. In the 1740s, the population of the town doubled from less than a hundred thousand. To the same extent that Calcutta gained from the Maratha raids, the regional state grew weaker. Unable to militarily deal with the raids, the ruling nawab made peace and ceded a large territory to the Marathas.

Shortly before Bengal faced these raids, a succession dispute broke out in the Carnatic, a South Indian state. The disputing parties were individually weak and made alliances with the English and the French East India Companies. Between 1740 and 1760, the English and the French fought three wars in this region, the battles being triggered by a new succession issue and by two European wars (the War of the Austrian Succession [1740–48] and the Seven Years' War [1756–63]). The hostilities in Deccan effectively ended in 1760, when the English East India Company prevailed and succeeded in securing the friendship of this wealthy, strategically situated but militarily dependent, Indian state.

A showdown had already begun in Bengal. Calcutta and lower Bengal were emerging as a major field of enterprise for European private traders, who were friends of East India Company officers. The dispute in Bengal had much to do with the limits of the nawab's sovereign power to tax Europeans. Again, the French and the Dutch opposed the English, and the English won the key battles (1757–64). In deciding the outcomes of these battles, the English company's territorial acquisitions proved a

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great advantage. The company could move troops easily between Madras and Calcutta, and it received help from Indian merchants living under its protection. Some of these merchants became prominent negotiators.

In 1764, the English East India Company defeated a North Indian army and was formally recognized as the de facto ruler of Bengal. The significance of the conquest was not lost on the Indian powers. The main military force, the Marathas, had their base in Central and western India. Almost all the other major powers were willing to enter into alliances with the company to meet the Maratha threat. Some of these alliances led to dependencies and further territorial acquisitions in the late eighteenth century. The Marathas were subdued in the early nineteenth century, and by 1818, the company's empire in India had largely taken its final shape.[25]

Immediately after the East India Company assumed power in 1765, state revenues were used to purchase cloth. This phase of taxing the peasant to pay the artisan did not last long, because money needed to be diverted to warfare as well. Territorial acquisition, therefore, affected the company's own future as a trading firm. In Bengal and Coromandel, state power meant that the company enforced measures to take closer control of its purchases. The system of intermediaries was not abolished, but the intermediaries who remained were subordinated to paid officers of the state. These employees were usually outsiders to the world of the weaver, and they were ready to abuse their policing powers. The system, therefore, caused much conflict.[26]

[25] The relationship between the English East India Company and the local business and political environment during the period of transition is the subject of much scholarship. Representative works should include Lakshmi Subramanian, *Indigenous Capital and Imperial Expansion: Bombay, Surat and the West Coast*, Delhi: Manohar, 1996; Pamela Nightingale, *Trade and Empire in Western India, 1784–1806*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1970; Sushil Chaudhury, *From Prosperity to Decline: Eighteenth-Century Bengal*, Delhi: Manohar, 1995. P. J. Marshall discusses relations between the company and settlers in two colonies with divergent trajectories in *The Making and Unmaking of Empires: Britain, India, and America, c. 1750–1783*, Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2005.

[26] Om Prakash, "From Negotiation to Coercion: Textile Manufacturing in India in the Eighteenth Century," *Modern Asian Studies* 41(5), 2007, pp. 1331–68; S. Arasaratnam, "Weavers, Merchants and Company: The Handloom Industry in Southeastern India, 1750–1790," *Indian Economic and Social History Review* 17(3), 1980, pp. 257–81; P. Swarnalatha, "Revolt, Testimony, Petition: Artisanal Protests in Colonial Andhra," *International Review of Social History* 46(59), 2001, pp. 107–29; Prasannan Parthasarathi, *The Transition to a Colonial Economy: Weavers, Merchants and Kings in South India, 1720–1800*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001; H. Hossain, "The Alienation

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Access to land revenue raised the hope that dependence on silver imports could now end. For a few years that hope was fulfilled. But again, the diversion of revenues to other uses forced the company to import silver at times.[27] Its political power, however, had made the company highly creditworthy in the Indian money market, and business with the bankers was placed on a secure foundation. Although warfare drained the budget, it also increased the demand for imported iron goods, helping the company to better balance its trade. In the eighteenth century, Indian princes who had come in contact with British enterprise and society, the nawabs of Carnatic and Awadh, for example, purchased a great deal of prefabricated European iron goods; sometimes they had the goods made locally. Founding cannons with European help was a popular occupation for the regional princes at this time.

The assumption of political power was the beginning of the end for the English East India Company as a trading firm. Warfare made its finances precarious and forced the company to negotiate a large loan from Parliament in 1772. The Parliament approved the loan in exchange for closer regulation of Indian administration.[28] The volume of trade was generally depressed, except for a few years before the Napoleonic Wars (1799–1815). Furthermore, private traders continued to consolidate their commercial fortunes at the expense of the company. Although indirectly helped by the new empire, they also resented the company's monopoly charter. It was largely this new opposition that saw the end of the royal charter that had granted monopoly of Indian Ocean trade to the East India Company in 1813.

The company as a state now faced the vexing problem of regulating private trade, the same issue that had brought down the nawab. The first parliamentary enquiry on justice in Bengal noted that soon after 1765, Europeans, "with or without Consent of the Presidency, dispersed themselves over the Country, and engaged in its interior Commerce, which often led them to interfere with the Judicature and Government of the Country." Institutions of justice affiliated with the local courts were already crumbling, with the result that "the Banyas of English Gentlemen, wherever they reside, entirely Govern the Courts of Judicature, and that

of Weavers: Impact of the Conflict between the Revenue and Commercial Interests of the East India Company," *Indian Economic and Social History Review* 16(3), 1979, pp. 323–45.

[27] H. V. Bowen, "Bullion for Trade, War, and Debt-Relief: British Movements of Silver to, around, and from Asia, 1760–1833," *Modern Asian Studies* 44(3), 2010, pp. 445–75.

[28] On the place of the company in British politics after the empire began, see H. V. Bowen, *The Business of Empire: The East India Company and Imperial Britain, 1756–1833*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2006.

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they even frequently sit as Judges in these Courts."[29] Such decentralized justice, formally endorsed in the case of disputes that broke out in the countryside, was convenient but contentious.

Until 1765, the English court in Calcutta was itself, in principle, merely a court conducted by an Indian landlord (zamindar). The company was no more than a Mughal zamindar after all. At the time, zamindari privileges included the right to "the Criminal, Civil, and Religious Jurisdiction of the District."[30] The English zamindari court in Calcutta began to supersede all other zamindari courts starting in April 1771, when, in a dispute between an English landlord of Calcutta and some of his defaulting agents, who had absconded to Rajshahi, the jurisdiction of the Calcutta courts was extended to all parts of Bengal.[31] The compass of the court was still extremely limited, and it covered commercial matters unevenly. Only in the nineteenth century did the court's scope become more general, as we will see in Chapter 7.

Transactions in knowledge

The collapse of the Mughal Empire and the efflorescence of merchant enterprise on the Indian coasts led to transactions in commercially useful industrial technologies. Recent scholarship has emphasized the fact that technological exchanges were two way. For example, European cotton-cloth printers in the eighteenth century developed capability by trying to reproduce techniques evident in Indian goods.[32] A similar argument has been made about cotton-spinning technology in eighteenth-century Britain.[33] That said, we know more about the technologies that came to India in the course of Indo-European trade than about the technologies that went out.

During the seventeenth century, Indian practices were behind the European ones in navigation. Instruments such as the telescope and

[29] British Parliamentary Papers, *Seventh Report from The Committee Of Secrecy Appointed To Enquire Into The State Of The East India Company. Together with an Appendix referred to in the said Report*, 1773, pp. 325–26.

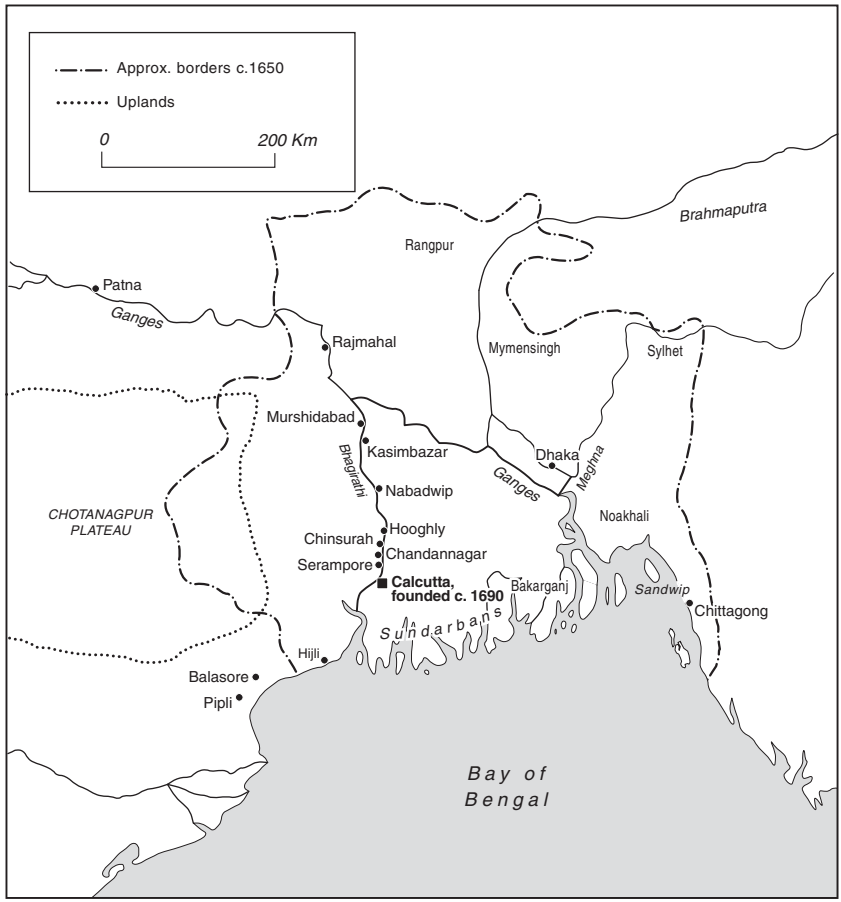
[30] Ibid., p. 330.

[31] Ibid., p. 331.

[32] Giorgio Riello, "Asian Knowledge and the Development of Calico Printing in Europe in the Seventeenth and Eighteenth Centuries," *Journal of Global History* 5(1), 2010, pp. 1–28.

[33] Prasannan Parthasarathi, *Why Europe Grew Rich and Asia Did Not: Global Economic Divergence, 1600–1850*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2011.

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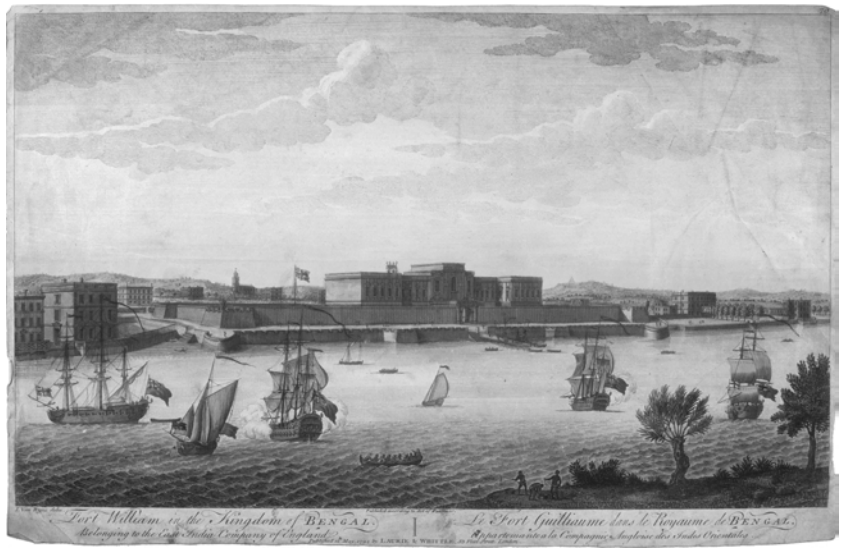


4.5. The Mughal province of Bengal showing towns and trade settlements, c. 1650.

compass were unknown in India. The heaviest Indian ships were constructed with little iron, which made them unsuitable for long voyages. European naval technology stimulated significant adaptation, learning, and improvement in India, one result of which was shipbuilding complexes such as Narsapur Peta on Coromandel.[34]

[34] Ahsan Jan Qaisar, *The Indian Response to European Technology and Culture (A.D. 1498–1707)*, Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1982, pp. 10–13; Zaheer Baber, *The Science of*

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4.6. Fort William, Calcutta, by an unknown painter, c. 1750. The old fort was constructed in 1701–2, about a decade after the English East India Company had acquired the rights of tenancy over the villages where Calcutta town was to appear. The fort was the site of major events and battles that transformed the company into the ruler of Bengal. By the time the picture was painted, Calcutta had already emerged as the most important trading center in Bengal, but its political transition was still a distant prospect. © Mary Evans Picture Library.

An externality of the navigation experiments was changes in metallurgy. One description of Indian shipbuilding on the western coast in the eighteenth century remarked that "their anchors are mostly European, our iron being much better, and better worked."[35] There is considerable evidence that even though iron casting was not a well-developed indigenous industry, many ship anchors were manufactured in ports using indigenous iron and ironsmiths who worked under European direction. In the seventeenth century, the Dutch East India Company set up ironworks near Palakole,

Empire: Scientific Knowledge, Civilization, and Colonial Rule in India, Albany: State University of New York Press, 1996; Sanjay Subrahmanyam, "A Note on Narsapur Peta: A 'Syncretic' Shipbuilding Center in South India, 1570–1700," *Journal of the Economic and Social History of the Orient* 31(3), 1988, pp. 305–11.

[35] John Henry Grose, *A Voyage to the East Indies*, London: S. Hooper, 1757, vol. 1, p. 109.

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